president, Aaron Burr, fathered two unacknowledged children with a woman believed to have been born in Calcutta, making his descendants among the earliest Indian-Americans. [75]

After American independence, one of the United States' first diplomatic missions in Asia was dispatched to Calcutta, although the first consul Benjamin Joy was not recognized by the East India Company. In the nineteenth century, ice farmed in the United States was shipped to India (the ice house in Chennai built by the American magnate Frederic Tudor later became associated with Swami Vivekananda, who briefly stayed there). Economic links between India and the United States also took some unexpected turns: the suspension of the cotton trade during the American Civil War resulted in a boom in Indian textile exports. India was certainly viewed with disdain by many prominent Americans, some of whom approved of aspects of British colonialism (such as former US president Ulysses Grant who visited in 1879). But the country and its culture also positively inspired such disparate characters as Henry David Thoreau, Mark Twain, and Robert Oppenheimer in the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries. [76]

For their part, many leading Indians ventured abroad during this period, including political leaders, lawyers, scientists, writers, and religious figures. Swami Vivekananda famously took part in the Parliament of the World's Religions in Chicago and travelled across the United States, Europe, and Asia. India's first Nobel Laureate Rabindranath Tagore also travelled widely on account of his celebrity, including to the United States, Argentina, Italy, Hungary, China, Indonesia, Japan, Germany, the Soviet Union, and Iran.

The growing Indian Independence movement also had strong international associations. Many Indian political elites—including those belonging to the first generation of post-Independence national leaders such as Mahatma Gandhi, Pandit Jawaharlal Nehru, and Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel—studied in the United Kingdom. Gandhi, of course, gained initial fame for his protests and organization in South Africa. (The anniversary of his return to India in 1915 is still commemorated in Pravasi Bharatiya Divas or the